

CDC & American Academy of Pediatrics (AAP) Food Safety Standards

Choking Prevention, Food Additives, and Allergen Protocols for Children Under 5

1. Primary Choking Hazards for Toddlers and Young Children

Choking is a leading cause of unintentional injury in children under 4 years old. Their airways are small and they have not developed mature chewing and swallowing coordination.

- **Whole Grapes and Cherry Tomatoes:** High choking risk due to spherical shape and slippery skin. Must always be sliced lengthwise into quarters before serving.
- **Hard Nuts and Whole Seeds:** Whole peanuts, cashews, and almonds should never be given to toddlers under 4 years. Smooth peanut butter must be thinly spread, never given in large spoonfuls.
- **Hot Dogs and Sausage Rounds:** Cylindrical shapes can completely occlude the trachea. Must be cut lengthwise then diced.
- **Popcorn and Hard Pretzels:** Sharp edges and inability to break down easily make them hazardous for children under age 4.
- **Raw Hard Vegetables:** Whole raw carrots and celery sticks must be cooked until soft or finely grated.

2. Dangerous Chemical Additives and Preservatives

- **Artificial Synthetic Dyes (Red 40 / Allura Red, Yellow 5 / Tartrazine / E102):** Linked in clinical studies to hyperactivity and behavioral disturbances in children. Avoid artificially colored snacks and candies.
- **Artificial Sweeteners (Aspartame, Sucralose, Acesulfame Potassium):** Unsuitable for pediatric diets; affects gut microbiome development and lacks required caloric nutrition.
- **High-Fructose Corn Syrup (HFCS):** Causes rapid blood glucose spikes and hepatic lipid accumulation. Should be excluded from infant and toddler products.
- **Nitrates and Nitrites:** Found in cured meats (bacon, cold cuts). Associated with carcinogenic nitrosamine formation and methemoglobinemia in vulnerable infants.